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A vision RCB collectively bought into

Despite not securing an IPL title, the men's team has maintained fervent fan support through effective marketing. RCB now wants to **couple this brand-building with on-field success** for its women's team.

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Before the first Women's Premier League auction, Royal Challengers Bangalore aimed to create a brand beyond just winning championships. It drew inspiration from its long-standing association with the Indian Premier League, where the men's team, despite not having won a title yet, continues to hold sway among home fans through its star players like Virat Kohli, AB de Villiers, and Chris Gayle, coupled with marketing and advertising muscle.

Now, RCB is trying to balance the same brand-building with on-field success, with its women's team. Smriti Mandhana's side, too, stumbled in the first season but has bounced back with a strong squad this year. **The RCB women played in front of their home crowd for the first time during the WPL 2024 season. In the heart of Bengaluru, the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium pulsated with energy as 26,000 voices merged into a deafening roar.** For Smriti Mandhana, the overwhelming reception during the toss at their tournament opener against UP Warriorz exemplified the unwavering home support.

In a chat with *Sportstar*, Mandhana said, "It was wonderful to be around the fans, especially during that toss. I don't think I will forget that moment for at least the next 2-3 years.

I'm definitely going to have that in the back of my head because that's pretty special. I was not able to hear what Mel (Jones) was saying there."

"We've heard a lot about the RCB fans but got a little

experience of what they actually bring, and more than pressure, we will take it as support. I heard Sophie (Molineux) say that the crowd was adding 20 runs to our total, which is true because they cheered every run, every wicket, and every dot as well," she added with a proud smile.

Even for a stalwart like Ellyse Perry, accustomed to the pinnacle of sporting achievement, RCB's homecoming was nothing short of revelatory. "It was a brand-new experience.

It was really special. And I think at the moment in women's cricket, those things keep happening, like it just gets bigger and better every year."

For Perry, whose illustrious career spans triumphs across cricketing formats and even on the football pitch, the allure of such experiences remains undiminished. "Even from the WPL last year, which was fantastic, coming to Bangalore here and now playing with our home fans at the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium, it was like a totally unique experience in all the years that I've played and never got a chance to do that. So it's pretty easy to be motivated and